

Saban

Surreal, seriously nonsensical short stories about a cafe that may or may not exist. *Where it exists is also debatable.*

By Lizard

1. Da Capo al Fine

There is nothing in between two particles. On a basic level. Don't argue.

I suppose 'nothing' itself is arguable, but here and today we shall pretend it exists. To say that there is nothing implies a 'something', which proves to be exceedingly problematic.

So, yes. We shall pretend nothing exists.

There is space between time. This space holds more nothing.

There are also bridges between worlds and threads of hours, seconds, days.

These threads mean nothing.

But nothing is a resting place. It needn't mean "bad".

All too often do we look forward to somethings that do not exist. Aimlessly we walk, like chickens with our heads cut off, until we find a semblance of peace and sit there— then we become ducks with big yellow bowlegs and peck at the sky.

For those who are not sure what they want, or perhaps knew at some point and forgot, there is still hope. Those lucky enough to stray from the path of reason might find themselves in the space between time; the nothing between atoms; the long, irrational expanse. Peacefully or otherwise, they might even begin to understand why dogs chase their tails in a circle and snakes eat their own ends.

Imposing on nothing, there is a small cafe.

There is a small cafe with no door, only two empty sides framed with wood, and rustic oak trim everywhere. The ceiling's neat lattice could be a checkerboard. Chessboard.

Whatever you feel up to playing.

Lined along the side are carafes— some small, some large, some for decoration only. And wide-mouthed coffee pots beside a metal machine that brews the liquid and stores beans in a compartment up top. They do not serve milk, sugar, or cream.

The countertop is high and lipped, barring all curious children, and the old, non-swivelling stools are too tall to climb.

Along the other side of the cafe, round tables with circular, backless stools are strewn about randomly. If three blind sparrows pointed to one location each, they would not get a better approximation of randomness. When I say random, or anything for that matter, I mean it.

Beside the social tables, there are others lined up by the side wall. Each lonely seat is placed directly, deliberately, underneath some painting.

Closest to the outside, a bad Mona Lisa. She blows a raspberry and attracts ants.

Tucked away at the very back, a Munsch. His nerves overtake him often. He represents the sort of person who comes to cafes alone. Confident in his intellectual superiority, he will remain there and enjoy the attention, though he professes to be shy.

In between, abstracts.

To a trained eye, the cafe might appear too clean. Uncannily so.

Its cosiness, down to the warm paper lamps and flowery wallpaper, is constructed. You will find no bustling street outside; no fuzzball barking, distracting you from your book as she flashes her collar: Princess.

Businessmen do not rush past, clutching their briefcases filled with papers and leaflets and capitalistic ire for nine-to-seven snoozefests. A shrivelled, orange body does not sleep on the side of the road, having given up entirely. Silence.

Even if the cafe were a hole-in-the-wall sort of establishment, you would expect some noise.

Humans, after all, show love through carefully constructed noises.

A lack of noise means an abundance of nothing.

Nothing, nothing, more nothing.

There is nothing in between two atoms.

It requires a seriously skilled entrepreneur to build something from nothing, don't you think?

Taxes are high these days, and prospective business owners need to have hedge funds and private jets before thinking of starting up.

In spite of all this pain, Cafe Saban continues to exist.

For those who are not sure what they want, or perhaps knew at some point and forgot, there is Cafe Saban. No need to figure out which way the door goes. Walk how you've always done it, one foot in front of the other, blundering along in a series of organised trips.

Enter and ask for a warm drink; coffee without milk.

Pet the cat who loves Munsch— an elitist. Find a seat.

The overhead bulb shines so softly that you do not realise it is trained on you and only you.

Today your story will spill out, regardless of how interesting the details are or what you're actually looking for. Nobody stops by unless they've a good reason, and for this reason, there is no need to hear one.

You have entered the space between time for a reason, yes.

The goal is to leave, to walk again, and finally to find your way back home.

2. Festivamente

Would you like a receipt with that?

Antoine calls himself Antoine, an act of rebellion against nobody in particular. Being humanlike but not human necessitates some very careful work on his part; work to act differently than the rest. So much does he believe in his power that he fears it. I am important and special, Antoine says of himself, whiskers twitching.

Nobody actually thinks he is a human.

He looks like a cat.

His round, mottled body swings like a pendulum whenever he rises, and so does the white triangle on his underside— hypnotic stuff. Like most cats, he takes solace in sleeping wherever is most inconvenient. Pats are alright so long as they're away from the triangle.

Don't get him started on Edvard Munch. Unhappy madmen who drink all day are representative of the human condition (according to Antoine) and their culture is very attractive to catkind, the domestic freak-kind (also according to Antoine). He talks about *The Scream* in English, saving his best words for then, prattling on and on until every customer excuses themselves. You don't get Munch's genius, close-minded fool, also— also— aren't you glad to see this painting in person? Earth hides good art from the commoners unless they pay, I think art should be free, Marx had a point, and oh, we aren't tied to Earth anyway...

No receipt. Great day, Morie.

3. Colla Voce

Morie, the human proprietor of Cafe Saban, calls herself Morie because she was born Morie. She secretly wishes she were born in a bed of ferns instead, free to live among plantkind instead of nothing. Ferns don't give names to their children.

The life of a fern is a peaceful, boring affair characterised by few milestones and strong collectivism. Antoine says it sounds stupid. Ferns can't drink frothed milk, he adds; they sit in sad pots and watch happy people talk. You can stare at customers just fine on two legs, loosened by the mouth and the body magnetic.

Hard disagree.

Morie does not like being human, but Antoine does.

Despite their differences, she cares for him just fine. Whenever the tables need washing, the dishes need scrubbing, or the lights need changing and a toolbox, she goes forth with Antoine perched on her shoulder. Claw-marks etch a treasure map into her skin. He will kill her, probably, if she protests against the whole thing, so she remains stoic about it.

You might not believe in loving someone and envying them at the same time.

I think it makes complete sense. When you've been with another for as long as Morie has known Antoine, you will understand.

In the space between time, friendships are necessary.

Keep them like an aching, infected tooth that screams,

I am alive. I am here. If anything, I am aware.

4. Assai

The gibberish man comes at 12:16 PM EST. I am not sure why an establishment in nothing requires time, but time there is. And time there will be.

Right when the clock ticks 12:16— it stops abruptly sometimes, then comes back alive with a hurried wave— he pushes his way through the nonexistent double doors of Cafe Saban.

Almost immediately, he begins to talk. Morie and Antoine give each other furtive back-and-forth looks, saying in telepath-speak: It's naptime and neither of us have had an espresso yet. Their eyes seize back and forth, lids faster than a hummingbird's wings.

“Hello,” Morie starts.

The gibberish man cannot hear her, beginning to speak louder— more angrily now, insistent and high-pitched. He wears a threadbare coat with twelve green buttons, which Morie counts, and four sewn patches. Paint crusts the edge of his rightmost sleeve.

Morie will watch and sip her tea.

Though Antoine tries to make sense of the gibberish man's message, his cattish brain finds itself drawn to the way his voice pitches up and down, side to side, like a keelboat with a baying hound at the helm.

Gibberish fills the otherwise empty Cafe Saban.

Nobody can escape it, and nobody understands a thing.

“Moon eclipse spectacle falls furtive facetious the will of will of swill swine pine dine round house fine time proposal create propose review write for self for it and then if you poor sometimes when if go says nay to wind.”

After ten minutes of speaking gibberish, the man tries to pour himself a cup of joe. He *definitely* calls coffee ‘joe’. He’s the sort, isn’t he— informal and always imposing on your space. On good days, comparing a joe-drinker to a java-drinker to a sad coffee-or-caffeine-drinker is below Morie, but today she lets her judgement slip.

Maybe Joe is this man’s brother, father, or husband (who has been liquefied for some strange reason), and maybe she deserves a terrible fate for making assumptions.

The paper lamps swell.

“Don’t mind me. I’ll just pour myself a cup of Joe,” he says, and leans over the counter.

“I can brew you some fresh coffee,” Morie offers instead. She feels bad.

In the meantime Antoine eavesdrops, his feline mug half-hidden behind a clump of potted ferns. Being normal himself, he only deals with normal customers, but they are a rare occurrence. He licks his paw and pretends to read Proust.

To Antoine’s chagrin, Saban serves more zebras than horses. Finding yourself in nothing necessitates a sort of eccentricity. Proper folk stay grounded; they stay ‘something’ and needn’t fall into liminal space. If Antoine were human, he would not be here.

“No, no! *Joe*. Not *coffee*. Superstitious superficial quip witticism frank dance dalliance.”

“Who is Joe?” Is the least Morie can do, especially without Antoine’s help.

“Just you wait. I’m about to pour a cup of Joe. Name dame train Spain Spaniard spire tint tincture illness potato dream sequential split tome forbid God draught drink spill spat wind wine wrong prong tong flung spin pink purple orange discus thrown list literally down the you in and I or if collide rock meteor fatality world down end of end of end.”

Over the counter, Morie notices his shoes. They fit him badly. The laces don’t match; one is tied properly, the other knotted up.

As incredible as Joe sounds, her and Antoine are sceptical. If he does something unexpected, like knocking over their big metal coffee machine, they will not turn a profit. And they will have given no answers to anybody at all.

“How about I get Joe for you instead?”

“Don’t want Joe anymore! Whip snip town orange buddhism lion...”

“What *do* you want, then?!”

“I don’t know what I want! I don’t know!”

The gibberish man replies. With every repetition, he grows louder until the sound is a siren and the victims are half-dead.

“I don’t know at all! Now leave me alone.”

Before Morie can rationalise his behaviour— before Antoine slowly lowers his Proust and prepares for large-scale warfare— the gibberish man turns tail. He runs away.

5. Armonioso

If Antoine strains, he can see the pulsing central vein on Morie's forehead. Someone should mine it for ore and stack bricks over the wide swath of skin. Not rudely. With consent.

Her forehead isn't *that* big... Just sizable, a less loaded word.

Morie would absolutely flip if he called her a tomato or despot or something worse. Animals are alright, but humans don't like 'animalistic' things. They don't want to be associated with lower-than behaviour, and as a result, they look down on cats.

"Pick me up! Let me see!" Antoine cries, weaving back and forth through her legs. These new renovations haven't been vetted by the Cat Committee.

"Give me... A second."

With all his noise, Morie can't properly replace a burnt-out lightbulb. Nothing— nothing, hah, get it— says "authentic" more than fake paper lanterns containing real, environmentally unfriendly devices. Sometimes cats are more trouble than they're worth.

"Go away," she sighs, "I'm not doing anything important."

"Oh yes you are."

An ordinary cafe, one full of people and life, would meet the soft patter of rain outside, tap-tap-tapping on the glass like little childrens' fingers. Petrichor still dampens the air, but artificially; what you'd smell after spraying rain-scented perfume with notes of vanilla and cardamom. Mud doesn't have either of those things. Morie admits a need for better ambient

scentscaping. Because Cafe Saban has no windows nor weather, she must work hard. No colour for miles and miles isn't exactly... Appealing.

On the topic of hard work, note Antoine's prowling of the perimeter and Morie dusting tables on her worn, tired tiptoes. She despises calling herself dead, even "not living" in the sense that you and I are. Humanity takes her like a wave, a new-age fad. Every morning, she dirties her clothes on purpose. If she did not want to claim exhaustion, she would not have to.

"I'm busy! If you'd just"-

"Meow. Meow. Meow."

"I'll kill you, Antoine..."

"Before you do," he interrupts, circling her with all the ease of a non-Newtonian fluid,

"Best look outside. Nothing's got company, and I think you should check it out."

His grey whiskers twitch expectantly.

Until Morie gives in and drops her lightbulb altogether, Antoine will wait.

"Fine."

There is a neat, single train track running outside Cafe Saban. A real track.

Morie doesn't believe him until she walks out to see it with her own two eyes, and even now, she feels more scepticism than interest. Trains, seriously?

It's an alright track, not particularly new or outdated. The sky (where there was once *no* sky) is a pallid colour reminiscent of an old, plague-ridden man's face—

Sad and foggy, for lack of new metaphors.

Morie hears an owl hoot, hoot, whoo. They are hidden somewhere in the creeping bushes and weeds that have now overtaken the entire “outside”. Cafe Saban sticks out, lined with white like a poorly rendered 3-D model.

She knows better than to question why Antoine, an inferior species, looks unfazed.

Stupid cat did something...

“Looks like you’ve torn the fabric of reality again.” Her words are pointed.

“Whoops!”

“Your claws hurt. Be careful with them.” Poisoned, even.

When something encroaches on nothing, *something* is amiss. Mouthful, I know. But it is true, and Morie and Antoine have experienced several similar events in the past. Antoine must be careful not to abuse his power, or train tracks with sickly grey skies will appear out of nowhere. He should stick to Munsch and Proust and pseudo-intellectual rambling.

“This could have been avoided if you stopped the lightbulb business and gave me a treat instead,” he sighs; an unhelpful note.

Morie opens her mouth to speak, but decides she will ignore him from here on out.

Despite their plight— and the budget cuts that come with reality detachment— she is calm.

She is even inspired to write a tune.

Now that my shop is gone,

I have a better view of the harvest moon.

6. Alla Sambuca

Shortly after the train tracks appear, Morie and Antoine are awoken by a steam engine's choo-choo. Four people and two kittens hop onto the platform, which is a small square of dirt, and enter the station, which is Cafe Saban. They move in rank and file, heads down like nine-to-five workers braving their daily toil, and stop behind the coffee counter.

“One vanilla latte. Small, please,” the first passenger says.

“Would you like a receipt with that?”

“I’ll pay it forward and cover the gentleman behind me.”

“...Receipt?” Morie cranes her neck to look at ‘the gentleman.’

“No, no. Just take my money.”

Passenger 1 sports a fluffy pink purse. If the universe ever chooses to deify one person, it will choose her. Money, kindness, and fake fur wrap around her heart, tight as saran, and choke the reddish skin around her under-adjusted gold bangles. Compression and spaghettification have been pressing all along, but cannot win— she fights back.

According to Antoine, money should die.

He cares little about paying it forward.

Behind Passenger 1 is Passenger 2. Though Morie tries her best to get a good look at him, she only sees what seems like a sculpture attached to his head. Multicoloured plastic snakes stand in place of hair. He, too, is imprisoned by something material.

“What do you want, then?” Morie calls out to him. “She’s paying for your order.”

“I want to talk. I’ve gotten myself into a sad accident,” he calls back.

“But make me an iced Americano. Light on the ice.”

Morie resists the evil and horrible urge to reply, “Looks like it, yeah. Your hair’s all screwed.” Instead, she notes down both orders and gets working.

The smell of good coffee— imported from somewhere serious— always lifts her spirits a tad, and once the beans are ground like table salt, she reminds herself of the strange and wondrous journey they took to die here. They are veterans. She is paying them homage by using the French press, catching their squeezed blood in a cup, and feeding someone just as honourable.

“Can you put mine into the star cup?” Passenger 1 asks.

“Star cup it is.”

Some time yesterday, Saban received two crates of star cups.

Neither Morie nor Antoine know why Passenger 1, having never visited before, acts like a regular. But she wants her star cup and will receive her star cup; a smooth piece of glazed porcelain with twinkling silver stars inside. Due to some manufacturing error, they found themselves there instead of the exterior.

“I can’t see the stars.”

“Take a seat and finish drinking,” Morie offers, “then they’ll come back.”

“Okay.”

She leaves fur and perfume in her wake, trailing behind gaudily like the streamers on a wedding car. The whole universe must watch.

Passenger 2 collects his order next. Sure enough, a nest of fake snakes rests atop his head. Morie will make a Medusa joke and he will ask what a Medusa is, then she will laugh it off and send him away. There is much sadness that comes with meeting an unaware, unread man.

“I clean hanging sculptures. Boss puts me on a harness and I use my feather duster. One of them fell on me, sorry,” he explains before leaving.

“You don’t need to be sorry. Good day.”

Poor fellow sits by the window for the next two hours, trying to rationalise his new face; to put it into language and find common denominators for how different things have become. Otherness has brought him here, and until he gathers enough courage, here he will remain. He deserves a star cup. Stars are dreams; his have dried up.

Third in line is an ambiguously gendered child.

Antoine likes them. He likes enigmas, especially when they aren’t trying to defy the world on purpose. They stick out and defeat dictators, their entire regimes, just by living and existing and being childish.

Usually, Antoine does not raise his back for anyone but Morie. Passenger 3 is the exception. Circling their velcroed shoes, he purrs praises in cat-speak and tells Morie to pour them some juice or something. Whatever kids drink these days.

“Want some juice?” Morie asks.

“Nuh uh! I want a Caffè Corretto Alla Sambuca.”

“Don’t give them that,” Passenger 4 butts in from behind, “it’s got liquor in it.”

The androgynous child is visibly flattened.

“Fine. I guess I’ll just go...”

And they walk away to sulk at the Munsch solo table. Two kittens trail behind them; one dark as night with mackerel stripes under their coat, and another with seal points.

By now, three customers (or five, depending on who counts as a customer) have found seats: Passenger 1 taking up an entire round table, Passenger 2 in the tall seat by the wall, and Passenger 3 playing with Antoine under Munsch’s shadow.

Business is faster than usual, which isn’t *good*, per se.

Just means that humans are more confused than usual, which points to...

What does it point to?

I’m not exactly sure. What I do know, though, is that Cafe Saban cannot provide answers, only listening ears. The flower-print wallpaper will harbour but not *cure* you.

“This is all your fault, Antoine,” Morie calls to him in a singsong voice.

The cat is busy playing with his revolutionary child and kittens, teaching them about art history and Marxism and the dawn of Anarchism and also, right, how to make Caffè Corretto Alla Sambucas at home. Because Morie won’t give a kid some leeway.

“Bah. Just wait ‘till it passes. I’m not responsible for every single person in the *entire* world.

They’ll leave eventually, hop back on that train, so on and so forth.”

Spread over the child’s table like a languid puddle, Antoine couldn’t care less.

“That cat’s bad news,” Passenger 4 butts in again.

“I know.”

“Anyway, uh, I’ll take a Skullcap tea. You guys got those?”

There will always be tea in stock, and Skullcap just happens to be her favourite. Morie wonders whether she has walked into a dream; a closed-off dream where reality is everywhere else but fantasy is between her and them.

Most customers, given their proclivities and quirks, prefer coffee.

“Of course! Honey or”-

“Nothing. I like my drinks bitter.”

Passenger 4 waits in silence. They wear a worn safari shirt and khaki slacks clean-pressed to hell and back. At the corners, their eyes crinkle like the underside of a candy wrapper. Why use porcelain star-cups when there are such incontestably bright forces to begin with?

“You seem almost too normal for Saban,” Morie jokes.

Once the tea leaves her hands, an uncomfortable emptiness stews in its place.

“I’m still looking for something,” Passenger 4 waves around, “as are the others.”

“But you won’t find it here, will you?”

“No, probably not.”

Morie is sad to see them go. Things *should* be that simple, or contain however much simplicity is acceptable to keep the tea hot for a little longer.

Some vital organ in her body has shrivelled up.

It throbs on and off, like a beat instead of a burn. Surgery will not help.

7. Alzate Sordini

Antoine was right. While Morie hates to be forthcoming about her mistakes, she concedes this time *only*. All four passengers (and two kittens) take the next train out of nothing. Shortly afterward, the train disappears altogether.

First goes the fur-clad, jewellery-choked woman, then the child, the statue cleaner and Passenger 4. Colour slowly fades from their land. No longer can Morie hear owls and the soft rustling of wind through leaves, nor the air that smells green and sharp with night. A palpable sense of absence remains, like someone has gone and struck through her painting with red marker. She doesn't know how to wash it out.

If she can wash something else, anything, it'll be dishes, so she cleans them instead of metaphysical crap.

They loan control. Feelings don't.

"Where do humans go when they die?" Morie probes, looking up from her cup-scrubbing mission to address Antoine.

She can't get in the nooks and crannies if two clashing materials— silver stars and porcelain edges— are fighting all the time.

"A matter of relativity, dear," Antoine meows.

"Whenever I ask a hard question, you say: 'A matter of relativity, dear', and never explain yourself. I'm sick of it."

"Morie, you've learned enough already. Find an answer... Or keep on with the dishes, so long as I'm not bothered again."

As compensation for yesterday's 'fast day', today is slow. Morie puts a bit of classical on the radio; some Bach and Handel and mesmeric, sweeping Debussy. Camille Saint-Saëns does not appear for quite some time, given his recency.

"If I say I'll go to hell, will I?"

Antoine stretches, arching his bristly back.

"You wouldn't want to go there. Same as how you wouldn't want to be reborn over and over again until some bizarre lesson is learned. I like the idea of, you know, going nowhere. Finding nothing, a state before birth and being."

As her rags sweep over the star cups, absent-mindedly and lazily, Morie thinks to the tune of Nocturne in E-flat major. She loves trills, grace notes, what makes music flourish and grow wings. E-flat major. God. Two more flats than a girl can handle. Life is more than she can handle, really, but she won't admit that.

"I don't like the idea of dying for nothing."

"...Then tell me yours."

The music soars up, up, up, until falling back down in a golden sun-shower.

It dips low, touches a high note, then bows at last to Etude Retrouvée, the closest human thing to fairy music.

"If angels play the trumpet all day, I'm not inclined to stay in heaven or any god's world. I want to die for piano— piano just like this, and hard, loud C major songs that knock my ears out," Morie finally admits. "So I guess it *is* relative."

8. Burletta

A man enters. He has a sort of far-away look about him; the kind you'd expect from a person who's just witnessed their own death. His face alone speaks in tongues, whispering something beyond English, crawling over every wall of the soundsphere until it forms a thin, sheer spiderweb.

Matted hair clings to the man's forehead. Morie traces its outline with her finger.

"Looks half-gone, doesn't he?" She asks Antoine discreetly.

"All gone. Nothing left but cloudstuff and regret."

With his heightened senses, Antoine can smell regret from miles away. His little muzzle curls in disgust after he catches a whiff.

"Well, let us see."

The man walks like both feet have separate agendas, which hitherto works alright until his left toe trips over nothingness and he falls flat. Several groans, less angry and more exhausted, come up. It is some kind of symbolic event— how he was almost there, just metres away from Saban, but could not make it without hurting himself first.

"Morning, sir. What would you like to order?"

Baby giraffes are birthed cruelly, Morie thinks.

The world expects them to walk as soon as possible.

"...*Order*? Is this my end? Am I ordering my punishment?"

"I don't see what you mean."

Upon closer inspection, he does look rather 'ended'. While living beings have the gloss of want in their eyes, dead bodies fix on a point behind your shoulder, somewhere indefinite and unattainable, with vacant stares.

"I mean, I mean- is this where a man goes when he dies?"

Morie and Antoine communicate like teenage girls sitting on opposite sides of a classroom. Despite their distance, they may still talk; hence the slick sideways glance, the upward nod, and the emergency triple blink.

"You'd better include women, too."

"Yes," Antoine chimes in. "Women deserve an afterlife. Perhaps more so than men."

Note how only teenage girls know the subtleties of their carefully-crafted, pervasive (in some gatekept sphere, at least) lexicon. They strike the perfect balance between closed practice and inclusion.

"I don't care about women!" The man interjects impatiently.

"What?"

"Wait. That came out horribly. I mean, I do care about women, but I'm here for myself."

Hurriedly, he opens his wallet. Its black leather mouth contains some credit cards, some debit cards, some point cards, many lottery tickets, and a slip of yellow paper that seems to be printed. The print, in typewritten serif, reads:

Author of _____, _____ dead at 34.

"I'm dead, see, and I've ruined everything before I found the time to fix it. Once I died, I found myself here, and now I'm... I don't know. The main issue is that I don't know."

Morie and Antoine share a knowing look. While he does not know, they do.

Their prior discussion about afterlives and all, that was dross. Saban sits in the middle, separate from organised religion, and does not associate with any other party. Metaphysical bits, the alteration of reality, junk tossed from someone's emotional baggage— Saban is to death as an Alcoholics Anonymous meeting is to Marie Antoinette. Minimal relation.

"My life was a mess," the man continues, making himself comfortable in a barstool by the coffee counter.

"Let's start from the top. About seven years ago, I received considerable attention for some books I had written. Mostly useless stuff, right, fantasy and not *good* fantasy at that, but the attention came and I secured good standing with my publishing company. Then I realised I had to put out new trash novels, so I hired someone to ghostwrite for me while I worked on what I really wanted. But deception doesn't matter. I also accidentally cheated on my wife. And ran into a motorcyclist last week."

"...How does one accidentally cheat on their wife?"

"Forgot I was married."

"Death is an excuse." Morie slides a cup of black coffee to him, free of charge, and adds,

"You'll be sad to know you haven't died yet."

The man is predictable in his ways. Once Morie says what should have been obvious, a palm comes crashing into his forehead— he slaps himself.

"Shit!"

The man does not appear mysterious, as he did before. He appears bare, naked, and defeated.

9. Maestro Collaboratore

Could-have-been is a powerful force. Reading the receipt, watching the hands whirl by, sitting opposite one another in silence... Fate is a long, long table. On one end rests your body; on the other rests your alternate selves. Their success depends on yours— how well you played with the hand given, and what your general score of satisfaction (on a scale of 1-10) may be.

Antoine's vulpine nose, so gracefully pointed in whisker-ish sculpture, mourns water by drinking it. By that metric, he would love to know about his alternate self and whether, oh joy, the good cat ended up pursuing a doctorate in something unusual like apiology or philosophy (with a hyper-specific specialisation).

On the other hand, Morie fears for her alternate self.

Her worries tend to follow this course:

She meets Morie 2, they speak, and Morie 2 brags about her success. Then Morie 1, the original who has been reduced to a number, will wilt like a winter crocus, petals falling one by one until naught but the chalky yellow stalk remains.

The stalk doesn't have practical significance— it furthers the metaphor and *maybe* represents bones, Morie decides after rationalising this all.

Then again, what if Morie 2 hurts her in some subtler, even worse way? What if Morie 1 sits, basking in the afterglow of a one-sided conversation, when Morie 2 suddenly begins to cry? Morie 1 must wonder who taught the girl to wear silence, and why she spoke while Morie 2 held water— some in her hand and some in her eyes. Horrible. Just horrible. *Customers* can't hold water; they're supposed to release it. For this anticipated betrayal of Saban's purpose, Morie decides that meeting her sadder self will be the worst possible outcome (out of two).

Now, I suppose we wouldn't have to worry about either outcome (both negative) if fate weren't cruel. But fate is a long, long table, and I believe we've been through this before?

Saban's very special, very liminal nature allows for hypotheticals to become real. Reality means nothing; neither does sense.

Plumbing the depths of the cafe's mind will yield, among other things,

"What if Morie and Antoine met their doppelgängers?"

"I give up on chess," Morie groans.

The lamps swell with a fervour that can only be explained by small, trapped fairies working minimum-wage jobs to keep them alight. Cheap labour yields blood, sweat, and tears.

Cafes, peaceful as they seem, are quite violent.

In lieu of payment, the fairies may watch her butcher the art of chess—brutally murder it.

"I giVe uP on cHeSs," Antoine repeats rudely.

"You need to understand, dear Morie; chess is a very, ah, how do I say it? Future-forward board game. Chess is great."

"Whoever invented the thing deserves a painful death." Morie crosses her arms, meaning business. The brown fabric of her apron bunches up in the space between chest and limb.

"...Because you're losing, yes?"

Antoine would cross his arms if he could. Making like bread, he shapes himself into a calico loaf and tucks his paws underneath.

"Maybe."

Right about then, Morie and Antoine 2 enter Cafe Saban.

Morie and Antoine 2 look exactly like Morie and Antoine 1.

The reduction to numbers will remain for convenience.

Morie 2 carries Antoine 2 with some difficulty— his 20 pounds spill out of her arms like pumpkin-spice-coloured bog slime— and her face betrays defeat. Immediately, Morie 1 feels the need to assert dominance over Morie 2. Her basest survival instincts say, “Don’t trust yourself. Especially when they exist in a separate body”.

Also, pumpkin spice is a terrible autumnal flavour. Any comparison to the thing is inherently bad. Antoine 1 prefers bergamot tea with frothed milk, hinted lavender (a soft wash over the flavour profile), and a touch of vanilla syrup. Fall and autumn needn’t taste like manufactured aesthetics. Like prose, autumn should be open to interpretation. His feline counterpart’s fur reminds him of that over-commercialized, over-sweetened ‘pumpkin’ junk; no room for creativity or critical thought. 0.5/10.

“Get out!” Morie yells at the guests, baring her teeth.

“What she said! Screw off!”

Morie and Antoine 2 pause, look at each other, then continue their journey forward. They walk like the originals, resemble them besides slight differences in colour gradation, but Morie and Antoine 1 find it hard to accept their new clones— second originals, inclusively.

“We don’t mean harm!” Morie 2 calls from a few metres away, toeing the line between Saban and nothing. Her gesture looks provocative, or so Morie 1 thinks.

“Right. We don’t. Is that chess?”

Antoine 2 leaps from his owner's arms and saunters his own, winding way down to the cafe. He is met with hisses and an unwelcome reception. Antoine v. Antoine fight in the way that most cats do, batting their non-lethal paws like little boxing gloves and mrow-ing all over.

"There can only be," Antoine 1 huffs between punches, "*one* of me! Damn it!"

"You're at least two pounds fatter! You take up more space, produce more methane, and therefore *you* deserve death more than I!"

"Low blow, Antoine! Low blow!"

Morie 1 and 2 look at each other knowingly. Despite their feelings— strange, elusive whirls of red that hide behind customer service smiles— they acknowledge some common ground. World peace does not and will never come in a day, but one must sign declarations anyway. The two Mories converge.

"Do you really want us to leave? We've come so far," Morie 2 pleads.

Seeing herself reflected back is... New, to say the least. She notices her freckles, bright even in the absence of sun, and the way her hair favours one side over the other. The exact shade, too, orangey-brown; and the texture, mutable. Proper, messy modern art.

"Please go. Start another cafe down the road."

The Antoines have worn each other out. They lie in a pile atop the chessboard.

Morie 2 notices them and laughs,

"Great idea. Careful, though— they've knocked over your game."

"Little buggers."

While Morie and Morie share some fun watching their vaguely French (Antoine sounds French, right?) cats ‘mrrp’ about, they acknowledge the could-have-beens of this meeting.

Could-have-been is a powerful force.

Alternate selves have the *potential* to provide insightful advice, some of which may or may not be earth-shatteringly important, but most— if not all— of the time, matters go awry and the seed of information germinates in a jar, then ferments, then smells horrible.

“So you don’t have anything special to say?” Morie 1 probes. She believes that could-have-beens are permanent, like cats, and will come around if you entice them.

“No, not really. I’m a semi-present college student, I read books, and I live alone in a rented apartment with Antoine. My major is, as of now, up in the air.”

“You’re ordinary, then?”

“Ordinary and sad as can be.” Morie 2 winks back.

A college-goer with spotty attendance. Not a homeowner, but somewhere between homeless and sheltered. Reading books doesn’t sound particularly special— hasn’t everyone tried that at some point? What interests her the most is the concept of a *real* Morie-Antoine duo.

Morie 1 assumed they were one with Saban’s nothingness, but looking down the table now proves her wrong. She stares into the face of fate; how it has cheated them all.

What does ordinary mean, anyway?

“Ten out of ten,” either Morie concludes.

10. Lontano

Morie has a dream. In this dream, she wakes to the dark sky outside her bedroom window— she has a bedroom here, as she has a dream— and stumbles upright. Suddenly, pushed thousands of miles away before she can understand, her feet find rocky sand and the smell of something marine— is that seaweed?— diffuses inward like carbon dioxide to a fern.

It is late, but not too late. That fatally cosy time between October and December, where light packs its bags and leaves feather-tailed clouds behind, seems to be upon her. Although Saban celebrates holidays and in-betweens out of respect, Morie senses an honest ‘time’ here.

This dream must be taking place in the world, then.

She imagines Morie 2, the pained college student, tugging at her layers and so desperately clutching onto old times as they slip, slip, slip away into the chalk-drawn horizon line. Everything was brighter before; sweeter; pastels vibrant like cotton candy she can no longer afford.

All around, suffrutescent purslane and melting maple branches frame the scene in a sort of surreal melancholia— a romanticization of her new pain, complete with colour grading and perfect panning and dolly zooms to induce headaches but also spur thought; “it represents her confusion”. Sometimes, Morie thinks, nothing needs to represent anything.

Oh, but she represents nothing, doesn’t she? Anything is broad and wide and hard to grasp.

Keeping her scarf tight against her neck, Morie sits inside the other like a little matryoshka doll. Divorcing oneself from comfortable past lives is hard, she’ll admit this. If she blurs her vision well enough, the rocks cutting through the water become tree trunks, and the water itself becomes a dusty blue line painted in one fell swoop.

Waves reach the shore every so often, splish-splashing softly, but they look lacklustre. Several ducks pass by the recessed alcove of water, but whenever Morie reaches her hand out or pretends to throw bread, they paddle far away. This and that, but with a bad twist. Ducks aren't supposed to paddle so fast.

Taking deep breaths, counting boxes with her fingers, Morie watches liquid move for the rocks and the ducks and the sky. Liquid is kind enough to form pockets of air where she can pause and take in the world; where her cheeks grow rosy and impermanence loves her. Even the stupid ducks deserve some modicum of love.

Antoine should be here, too, to share in the love. Antoine should be everywhere that she is, otherwise "is" doesn't deserve such weight.

A lone squirrel stares at her from its maple perch. *Why do you think so much?* It asks.

Antoine would devour him— rabid anti-intellectual propagandists, those rodents.

I don't, fartface. You just think too little.

Because Antoine has disappeared, Morie and the squirrel have a stare-off until she backs away, loses on purpose, then turns tail down the path that might've led her here. Clouds make way for moonlight, fading to soft grey wisps on the covered sky. They follow Morie like calico cat fur and putter-putter fish scale exhaust.

Dreams are unfortunately fickle, notoriously bad actors, and frequently fall victim to the reconstructive memory model. Artists are victims, too; they can never live without art on the brain. Artful dreams eat through their beds every night— double whammy.

If I remember this tomorrow, Morie vows, I'll write a real good memoir.

11. Subito

Morie does not, in fact, remember it tomorrow.

“I had a real good dream last night,” Morie sighs, “but I can’t remember what it was about. How do writers and the like... how do they actualize their dream sequences? I’m missing something.”

“You’re missing Nothing, because we are nothing,” Antoine says cheekily. His wide body splays all across the barstool-style seats tucked into the main counter. If he were smaller he might take up one cushion, maybe going unnoticed, but his full length spans three. Impressive and terrifying. Passersby have to see him, or they’d be blind.

Morie seems dissatisfied with her cat friend’s answer. She throws a searing glare in his direction and nearly singes his outer crop of fur.

Having already meditated on loneliness, she stops at another hot topic; writing. The man who thought he’d died was a writer, but evidently not a good one. Accidental cheating and fantasy-writing come hand in hand because correlation always equals causation. Morie uses him as a reason to revisit literature, deciding she falls in the realm of surreal fiction. She’s the sort of book you read, stare at very quizzically, and put down when you’re ready to return to taxes and tents on the side of the road and, for better or worse, civilization.

“I don’t want to be that kind of book.”

“What are you on about now, Morie?”

“I want to be a peaceful novel for old women. I want to be a cookbook, even.”

“...Okay.”

Morie rests her chin in an open palm and stares out the colour-absent window. Ideas zip through the air like angry divorcees. There must be change, she decides. No use thinking about writing, or thinking at all, when none of these thoughts will help Saban. Actualizing the cookbook vision, like how authors— with their fickle, verdigris-tinted dreams— put concepts into words, seems like a better plan.

“I’m not going to be the green stuff on silver,” she emphasises, adding,
“What do we sell here, anyway?”

Saban doesn’t have glass pastry cases. They have no pastries whatsoever, which is rather counterproductive to money-making. No one enters a cafe looking for coffee alone, and though their coffee might be the best in all of Nothing, it hurts the stomach to drink that stuff without any solid food.

Antoine’s eyes light up as they pass the absent pastry case. He finally understands.

“We don’t sell much, you’re right...”

“You get me.”

“Liminality is terrifying— and if prospective customers have no incentive to come, they’ll wander forever without our help.”

“You *get* me! Let’s fix it.”

Morie and Antoine reach a strong mutual understanding after one “let’s fix it”. Goals now exist, they needn’t be materialised further, and procrastination is neither owner’s preferred mode of work. In fact, they prefer to rush; and rush, they do.

Morie splits from Antoine like oil from water and immediately begins measuring the counter. This unusual situation— agreeing after three sentences, of course— deserves her full working capacity. She can't hesitate, lest Antoine change his mind.

Needing little but teamwork, they spring into action. Their plans line up as such:

- 1) Bend reality for some fresh new renovations (glass pastry case, fancier menu board)
- 2) Reproduce homey dishes that exist in the world but not Saban (pancakes?)
- 3) Bask in the fruit of many customers (lost human beings)
- 4) Rest.

Antoine can take the reality-bending (so long as he doesn't rip another hole into its fabric), and Morie can take the cooking (so long as she doesn't burn a hole into its fabric). Tying her apron tight and squeezing her great puff of hair into a net, she begins with pancakes. Box mix is readily available 'round these parts.

Instead of "just adding water", she adds one saucer of buttermilk to spite the instructions. They don't know about fine dining. Oh, right. And proper pancakes deserve fluffiness, hence the egg whites and lemon juice she veers completely off-course to prepare. In another bowl, Morie beats them from liquid foam to a solid, shaving-cream-esque concoction. If she were real, she'd eat the stuff right then and there.

"Antoine, come look! It's successful," she says from her ingredient-folding station. Unfortunately, Antoine is busy with topology— he needs to figure out how mugs turn into donuts and whatnot.

"I'm sure it is, yes!" He yawns, not looking at her once.

Unperturbed by her feline friend, Morie materialises a skillet and heating element on an unoccupied portion of the coffee preparation area. She does so without topological expertise. Antoine is overdramatic.

After some time— and two burnt trial pancakes— the warm, heavy smell of calorie-dense food saturates Saban’s scentscape; and it smells *good*. There aren’t any better adjectives than “good”. Good equates to simple satisfaction; which equates to a carbohydrate that stimulates your salivary glands and stomach walls; which equates to biological perfection. Morie can best describe it as breadlike, but she knows very little about bread.

If bread were beneficent, fine with all your vices, and indulgently buttery, then perhaps she’d make a better comparison.

“It’s really successful. Really, seriously successful.” She tries for Antoine’s ears yet again.

“Could do with strawberries, eh? And some whipped cream, if you’re bold.”

His feline nose (and culinary spirit) perks up, sending Morie into another whirlwind of creation. As for him, he’s made what looks like a passable, real display case— the glass only disappears when you give it a solid shove. He spends the better part of an hour watching Morie’s strawberry syrup-making process instead of, you know, fixing the case’s reality blip. Cats don’t believe in righteousness.

Once everything falls into place, he demands that he be the first pancake-tester—

“In case you’ve poisoned the batter,” is his reasoning.

“I deserve a taste first. That’ll tell you whether I’ve poisoned it or not,” is her reasoning.

Regretfully, he lets up and licks the plate.

The culinary arts are too often touted as inferior compared to fine art and literature and breakdancing. While breakdancing may be a smidge better, baking most definitely invites strong competition. Even Michelangelo, Antoine reasons, couldn't cook up a stack of pancakes if his life depended on it. He couldn't drizzle syrup over fresh-cut strawberry slices, and he sure as *hell* couldn't distribute whipped cream for a dilapidated but deliberate finish. As rivulets of sugary red cascade down to the plate, like a waterfall over rocks (since he's feeling poetic), Antoine drinks the pool that follows.

"Feline diabetes is no joke," Morie hisses, grabbing him by the scruff.

"You only live once. And because we live forever, I can't develop diabetes. Checkmate and checkmate again. Let me enjoy myself!"

Antoine's syrup-licking speed significantly increases.

What dulls his mood— in the slightest, most nagging way possible— is the thought of others taking their food. He hadn't thought about it before, but who bosses them around?

Who tells them that they must be the shepherds of Nothing?

"Hey," Antoine suggests through mouthfuls of pancake, "We should keep this renovation to ourselves. Enjoy the new menu as much as possible before all the nutjobs come in"—

Morie plans to reprimand him, but has no time. His idea disappears at the sound of rapidly advancing footsteps in couplets, stern as an army march.

Two heads freeze over their shared pancake stack. One fork clatters to the ground.

Antoine slinks away, taking advantage of his non-Newtonian properties, and poor Morie is left alone with the strange, uniformed human that enters.

12. Stringendo

The food safety inspector sports a clean-pressed black jacket with flaps on its shoulder pads and sixteen shiny, colourful ribbon squares on its left breast pocket; the one closest to the heart, where the home is. On its right breast pocket, Morie notices a laminated name tag with the all-capital words, “FOOD SAFETY INSPECTOR.”

As if some sleeper agent’s instincts overtake her, Morie stands pin-straight and salutes— an uneducated salute that overshoots the browline by about two inches, coming clean above her puff of hair like a fern. The food safety inspector frowns.

Eyes locked on Morie, she carefully slips a notebook from nowhere in particular and begins to jot something down with a pen from nowhere in particular.

Nothing is a real place, yes, but *nowhere* is terrifying.

“Would you like a receipt with that?” Morie asks instinctively. Wait, that’s not-

Somehow the overhead lamps turn to cheap strobe, and the Munsch becomes an obvious forgery. Antoine should be here; he’d lose his overextended mind.

“Asking for receipts before taking orders is against protocol.”

“Yes, of course. My bad. I’ll take your order”-

As she sidles over to the counter, having stood dumbly for longer than expected, her legs tremble like two stick bugs. Not sticks, though; only their crude biological imitations.

Never ferns.

Everyone has been nervous at some point, Morie knows, but her nervousness feels particularly sour. Anger (from Antoine's betrayal) and confusion (from Saban's first inspection) coagulate into one hard, solid mass of bad.

Dusting off the new display case with her right hand and leaning awkwardly with her left, she presents the better Saban and prays to every force that it'll be enough.

"So. What would you like today?"

Instead of replying, the food safety inspector scribbles down notes. A frown is stuck onto her face— like some sort of upside down Commedia dell'arte mask where the eyebrows are the mouth and the nose is a devilish, flicking tongue.

Morie wishes she'd just turn to stone and die.

"Unfortunately, Morie— I'm not here on the pretence of a food review. According to,"

She flips back a few pages in her notebook,

"Several complaints, Cafe Saban is *not* operating under industry standard."

"What?"

With teenage fury, Morie plugs the smoke threatening to burst from her ears and weighs up every recent customer. None left unhappily, or so she remembers... But then again, modern conventions are such that the unhappy do not speak. They only sulk away.

"Yes, well... One man complained, saying 'Proust weather cat orange fever zone peel smell torrential smooth' about your service. Essentially, he meant 'they didn't help me one bit'."

"That was a fluke," Morie thinks out loud. Wait, that's *definitely* not-

The food safety inspector, whose hair sits so tightly against her scalp that she needs no helmet on bike rides, is obviously unhappy with this. Both Commedia eyebrows curve down.

“Regardless,” she continues, clearing her throat for no one, “I have more. A certain Passenger 1 said her vanilla latte was a tad too bitter (because of the stars; they weren’t aligned right). Passenger 2 read up on Medusa and said you insulted him quite gravely. Passenger 3 said you denied them an alcoholic beverage— but to be fair, Saban has no licence to serve alcohol.”

If ‘industry standard’ means perfection, then no serious establishments should stay open. Saban exists to gently nudge, if not slap, folks in the right direction. It’s a learning experience rather than an enjoyable one. Although Morie will admit that she decorates the cafe very prettily on purpose, customers never come for the food or the ambiance or the anything. They come because they’re lost. They come for the Nothing.

“Oh— and an award-winning author called you a homewrecker. Any idea about that?”

“...Many ideas,” Morie says. The inspector’s eyes light up curiously, but she doesn’t pry.

“Yes, alright, ah.. My last note comes from 2 Eirom. This one had no specific complaints, but did tell me to pass a message on.”

At this, Concerto for 4 Violins & Cello in B Minor begins to play in Morie’s head— her brand new leitmotif. She can always trust the other end of the table.

“What sort of message?” She asks tentatively; excitedly.

“Ehh, something like ‘fight.’ Any use?”

“...Many uses.”

13. Sforzando

Morie excuses herself to the back storage-room, which did not exist until three minutes ago. Antoine created this room out of sheer terror, slipping all the way through reality until he found a nice space to sit in.

Here, he sleeps in a new box— one lined with red velvet on the bottom and sides, smelling of bergamot and petitgrain and rich floral heritage. Antoine considered soundproofing it at first, but later decided that Munsch would condemn him for such cowardice.

“Antoine,” Morie whispers aggressively, “nice box. Now come out and help me.”

“What? Oh, what? I can’t bear the weight of life any longer. Whether I may even be *considered* alive is a pressing question, my dear Morie.”

“Not the time. We’re under attack.”

Because cats, bless them, can furrow their brow muscles and make a whole variety of expressions if they so desire, Antoine quite easily conveys his apathy.

“I know we’re under attack. That’s why I’m hiding here,” he explains.

His little calico face is too endearing to smack.

“No, you’re not.”

“What do you mean I’m not? I very clearly *am*, and”-

Because cats, bless them, are often between 10-20 pounds, they can be lifted without significant effort. Morie quite easily tosses him over her shoulder, bursting out of the storage room with two spatulas and a bergamot-scented trail.

14. Volante

The food safety inspector does not expect a short, aproned girl and an overweight calico cat to come storming out of the storage room, but she does not seem surprised either. As a matter of fact, she's quite naturally prepared for these things.

She even has a sword on hand if the going gets rough.

"Cats aren't allowed in food service establishments," she reminds them, smoothing down her chalkboard-coloured uniform and readying the sword, which materialises all of a sudden.

"Die!" Morie replies.

The worst part about fighting food safety inspectors is the fact that they, too, know how to toy with Nothing. Nothing is ever set in stone.

Fully motivated, Morie and Antoine charge— the latter of whom takes his time. Neither proprietor has ever fought; most misplaced authorities leave after some careful convincing, and those who don't eventually come around.

How does one fight? Morie asks herself.

Antoine catches her eye like always.

Hit. With your spatula, he suggests, settling down at a solo table under Munsch.

Morie nods conspicuously. Then, she dashes past the armed inspector and attempts to clock her in the back of the head. Her arms wind up, every muscle tenses excitedly, the little lamp-fairies begin an elaborate cheerleading routine, the world breathes, and she swings.

Usually, this is it; one coup de grâce and stuff, you know, happens.

But instead of metal on bone, Morie hears air whoosh past.

This may not be a pancake-walk.

Antoine slowly rises to his paws and, as Morie and the inspector exchange unrealistic blows, considers his options. He's never tried to grab anything himself. Unlike the lucky few afflicted with polydactyly, his body does not suit grabbing well.

Nothing will allow it, though— if he comes up with a real good, ingenious explanation.

And he *is* a genius. He knows it.

In the background, Morie dodges fatal attacks. She knocks down two tables, whose legs buckle under stress, and one lamp, whose fairy-guts spill into the world of electricity and disappear altogether. Food inspector training school must be bootcamp, she reckons.

A bootcamp run by gods, demons, and antagonistic forces beyond her control.

(He is a genius. He knows it. If only he could)-

Morie squeals when the inspector's rational sword comes to cleave her in two, meting out a neat arc of judgement. It nearly succeeds, but she pulls a reality-bending drop and somersault and somehow ends the combination behind the display case.

Self-delusion isn't self-delusion here; it's truth.

(Geniuses typically think faster than this, don't they?)

(Oh, wait. Eureka.)

Antoine, after several minutes under the swirling mass of hypochondriacal anxiety that is The Scream, finally comes up with an idea. He licks his paw, as distinguished gentlemen do.

Letting Morie hold her own for a while longer, he jumps onto the service counter and paws at the unfinished pancake stack. It rests on a plate, and the plate rests on a smooth surface, and he rests on this surface too— and according to some rule, it'll all go sailing if he pushes hard enough. So long as the stack hits her somewhere, the inspector should be distracted.

He does feel bad about wasting a perfectly good stack of butter, flour and fluff, but desperate times call for feline measures. It's either one less dessert or no desserts ever again.

Morie drops her spatulas in a clumsy dodge, then drops her body— or trips, whatever the kids call it these days. The food safety inspector raises her mythical sword. With the deadpan criminal face you'd see followed by "I'm just doing my job", she says, "I'm not *just* doing my job. I'm working overtime for you two."

Morie sighs. Falling at the hand of a murderous food safety inspector was never on her bucket list. Before the blow hits, she sees herself in college; over grey swirling waters; on a train to a special cafe, and watches her real "life" flash amidst these hypotheticals.

If she disappears today, at least she'll experience the life of a fern later.

Some things just aren't meant to be.

"Heads up, Morie!"

Antoine's meow cuts through her depressive silence, and a projectile full of pancake scraps comes sailing towards the enemy's body with enough force to launch a Mars-bound rocketship. Once she turns, bewildered, Morie rearms herself and swings again.

She never *really* wanted to lose. 'Twas just rumination.

15. Rallentando

What happens after the fact isn't important, but would seem so if the end appeared all happily and shining without context. Importance always relies on context.

Morie's swing did not miss— which is to be expected.

Her spatula hit so well, in fact, that she flattened the food safety inspector into a two-dimensional sheet of yellow paper. For safekeeping, she folded the sheet into a star and tied a little bit of twine around one point. Antoine advised her to string it from the doorless front door, which she did rather triumphantly.

The act felt like victory; like an ancient warrior with his favourite severed head display. Except Morie and Antoine's severed head still lived— just in paper form, where it couldn't talk about industry standards any longer.

Once the fog of war had calmed, Morie fixed the fake paper lamp and apologised very sincerely to its fairies. Then she steeped enough Skullcap tea to telepathically contact Passenger 4 but, in a disappointed slump, found herself on voice-mail.

“Are we murderers?” Morie asks, tapping her fingers on the counter as she mulls about.

“Probably not. Things don't die in Nothing,” Antoine reassures her.

“You know, Antoine— it doesn't matter what people think is right. They're always wrong somehow, and when they *know* they're wrong... they rush headlong into the thing like idiots. I can't be mad at our customers for complaining.”

“Right on. Give a human two good options and they'll always choose the third.”

16. Tutti

Despite the conclusion that humans are inherently flawed, a certain subset will come to pay their respects—which will surprise Morie and Antoine to the point that they'll deny ever insulting humankind. Life is full of surprises.

Like clockwork, a moon rises to meet the blank sky and a quickly-materialising train stops before Café Saban's front entrance.

Antoine can feel the gravel on his paws again. This time around, it isn't his fault.

Ears perked, he half-wants to chase after owls and things that go bump in the dark; but he stops himself, for gentlemanly and intellectual duties do not overlap with feline duties.

He gave up being a cat quite some time ago.

Only the attitude remains, and even that is muffled by pretend.

"We've got customers," he calls to Morie.

"*Customers?* Surely not the ones who tipped us off."

"The very same."

Instead of anger, a very sad pit-like feeling overtakes the two of them. Worst-case scenarios flit around the air like little buzzes of electricity, and Morie goes so far as to wonder whether the customers want her dead; she's destroyed their food safety inspector, after all.

Quietly, she waits by the door with Antoine curled in her arms.

He purrs. Apparently purring is all the rage.

It helps heal broken bones, though he's not quite sure about muscles.

One by one, a set of familiar customers come filing in. There is a peppier edge to their step; as if they entered the day sufficiently caffeinated, did several productive things, and went home still-energised. Heads up like proud ostriches, each customer takes extra care to step over the Saban threshold— not on— and glance at the food safety inspector as they pass.

“She folded beautifully,” Passenger 1 points out. Her hair, curled in about seventeen tight golden ringlets, bounces as she walks. The universe still bows to her; no difference there. She takes a seat near the back, operating under the calm impression that no matter where she sits, everyone will notice. Everyone *does* notice, but they pull away eventually.

“She stayed true to her profession,” Passenger 2 agrees. He’s since extracted the plastic snakes from his head and sports a full, shining shield of baldness in place. The “Medusa” joke doesn’t bother him much anymore.

He will admit its cleverness; he cleans statues, statues are stone, et cetera.

“She called my mum,” Passenger 3 sulks. Only the slightest hint of appreciation tinges their voice. Here for someone other than the inspector, they run to pet Antoine first— who greets them with an arched back and free pancakes.

Passenger 4, to Morie’s dismay, is nowhere.

Morie and Antoine 2 won’t show up either, but she knows this.

Morie watches as Antoine and the androgynous child hit it off; as Passenger 1 helps herself to a star cup without permission; as Passenger 2 combs his invisible locks.

None of them have the worst-case scenario in mind, but she half-wishes they did.

About ten minutes later, the gibberish man and famous author enter hand in hand. What a great pair, Morie thinks bitterly— wordless and word-burdened. Opposites attract, but she has no friend to meet. Does that imply her lack of an opposite? Is she everywhere?

The hollow place where *something* should beat is shrivelling and sinking into itself.

“She didn’t translate my complaint right,” the gibberish man says in the background.

“She paraphrased me greatly,” the author agrees. People bond over the strangest problems.

Once the dull din of chatter fills Saban’s air, Morie and Antoine reconvene. Antoine seems pleasantly surprised, fur mussed from a good petting, but Morie seems worse than usual.

Her bangs are askew, and she holds dilemmas she can’t exactly explain.

Even so, Antoine urges her to try.

“You’re angry. Why?”

“And you’re not? They come back, pay their respects to the inspector— which is beyond what I expected, but still— order zilch, then act like it’s alright? *I’m* not alright.”

Morie lets out a huff of pressurised breath and leans against the counter to catch it. She keeps her voice low, but listening ears from here and there and around are perked already.

“Somehow I sense that their mild disrespect isn’t what ticks you off,” Antoine suggests.

“..Then what is?”

Because Nothing follows the same laws as soap operas, Passenger 4 walks in.

Passenger 4 walks in, and Morie brightens like a flower finally courting the sun.

“I’m a little late,” they say quietly, “hope I’m not disturbing this party. Just wanted to let you all know that the next train is delayed, and we’d better set off now”-

Before they finish, Morie sets a teacup and saucer at the nicest available table— which also happens to be in conversation distance with the counter.

“Tea? On the house?”

Passenger 4 looks past Morie wistfully, as if the one square of wallpaper behind her ear deserves special attention. Maybe it loved them in a past life.

“Afraid I don’t have time. We really *should* leave now,” they press, addressing the last bit to the customers. Several well-settled ones groan. Morie groans.

Nothing— ‘nothing’ in every way— hurts more than unmet expectations. Antoine senses Morie’s disappointment, palpable and thick in the atmosphere, rising up like a lost gas, but raises no solutions. He hates giving obvious solutions. And anyway, he’s busy moping about someone else’s departure— namely, the androgynous child whose parents seem like *real* crooks. God, what kind of monsters would prohibit such an impressionable, adorable kid from playing violent video games? Modern tragedy.

Morie wipes down already-clean tables until her hands turn red.

She waves the customers a tentative goodbye, and picks up after them when they rise, sadly but surely. It’s been a while since she cleaned.

“Will you be able to find your way home alright?” Morie asks when Passenger 4 comes past her field of view. Nobody sane travels Nothing without a train or destination in mind— and these folk were aimless, last time she checked.

“Of course,” they laugh, “we know the way.”

Passenger 1 pitches in. “Your service isn’t very good, but we think it worked.”

She casts an awkward glance at the origami star that once was a food safety inspector, then rises in a flourish and bows.

Passenger 2 cocks his bald head. “Yes, seems like it did.”

Passenger 3 adds a definite, “Ditto.” The gibberish man and author nod.

Without much fanfare, they all walk into the blankness, Passenger 4 leading the charge. Morie notices that the gibberish man’s shoes look alright for once. The author walks regularly, one foot in front of the other, and is self-assured that each step will work out somehow. Baby giraffes *do* grow up.

Suddenly, Morie remembers a thing she’d been meaning to ask.

“You in the khaki! Hey!”

“...Hmm?” Passenger 4 turns around, half-enshrouded in empty space.

“Did you find what you were looking for?”

Time slows, like in the tense second before splitting the atom -- or at least, what she imagines of that second. Morie steels herself and focuses on the disappearing neutral of their pants.

“Not here, but yes,” they finally say.

“Yes, I did.”

Despite previous letdowns, Morie can’t help but feel proud.

17. Tranquillo

Sunsets do not often fall on Saban.

Tonight, however, is a rare exception.

Morie and Antoine sit on the grassy hill that recently materialised beside Saban.

They watch the sunset that *also* recently materialised in the newborn sky.

Against a dusky blue backdrop, flashes of orange streak past like dancing tiger stripes, cotton-candy pink hanging off each edge— and even further out, magenta with barely any form; closer to loose smoke than concrete cloud. In the centre, confident in its power, sits one fiery ball of yellow-white light that burns the eyes.

Even now, Antoine is thinking business. Perhaps they could start an ice-cream gig and come out with a flavour of sorbet that mimics these colours. Call it Sunset Sorbet. Alliteration.

“This is pretty,” Morie sighs. She toys with the daisy chain in her lap, since anything can be anything these days, and stares boldly at the sun; blindness is for pansies.

“Very pretty. I can see why people like the real world.”

While Antoine continues thinking business, Morie thinks life. She thinks about her current state of being and matter, which she doesn’t mind but isn’t particularly satisfied with either. Fernhood has always called out to her. That, and...

“Antoine?”

“Yes?” His whiskers twitch expectantly.

“I think we’re in need of a serious vacation.”

“To where?” He asks, not quite sold on the idea yet.

Business clouds his head, thick and heavy over the mind-city, although there *is* still the problem of operating under capitalism and whatnot. What was that one bit— no ethical consumption under...?

“Oh, I don’t know. Mongolia! Iceland! Florida, for all I care.”

“I like Florida. Nice and hot down there, and they’ve got cat-friendly hotels.”

“Florida it is,” Morie concludes with the satisfaction of a good auctioneer.

Somehow, choosing a destination takes less time than she thought.

They’re both so eager to take a trip that they don’t *really* mind where.

A new figure approaches the cafe, but Morie and Antoine are already heading in to pack their bags. Morie waggles her index finger at then, shouting from over the hill,

“No can do! We’re on *vacation*!”

And puts up a hastily-drawn sign. She sketches her and Antoine’s faces in permanent marker with a firm and ominous “COME BACK LATER.”

Both proprietors know that their work will never end. This is only a short break.

People, after all, never lose the ability to lose themselves; they run around, around, and around until finding Saban. There, they either pry a solution from the cold, dead hands of fate or leave, dissatisfied. It’s usually the latter.

For the time being, little lost sheep and androgynous children and ruinous writers and the like— well, they’ll have to make do. Even shepherds need vacations.

18. Fine

There is a space in Nothing. This space holds more nothing.

There are also bridges between worlds and threads of hours, seconds, days.

These threads mean nothing.

But nothing is a resting place. It needn't mean "bad".

All too often do we look forward to somethings that do not exist. Aimlessly we walk, like chickens with our heads cut off, until we find a semblance of peace and sit there— then we become giraffes with big yellow bowlegs and eat at the sky.

For those who are not sure what they want, or perhaps knew at some point and forgot, there is still hope. Those lucky enough to stray from the path of reason might find themselves in the space between time; the nothing between particles; the long, irrational expanse.

Peacefully or otherwise, they might even begin to understand why dogs chase their tails in a circle and snakes eat their own ends.

Imposing on nothing, there is an answer.

There is an answer; and a small cafe named Saban; and a well-trodden front door that may not really be a door, but serves its purpose anyway.

Currently, Saban is on a little Saban-tical. Sabbatical.

Those who look will be sorely disappointed, since its proprietors have gone on vacation to... Mongolia! Iceland! Florida, for all I care.

They've gone to somewhere very real, where time passes by and the rules of reality apply rather stringently. Over there, humans show love with erratic noises and great gestures like the middle finger— or better yet, the gang sign. Dystopian skyscrapers cut through the sky, bustling streets cut through the earth, and there are more than enough barking fuzzballs to fill your nightmares with “Princess”.

Amidst this dirty, grimy grandeur, shrivelled bodies sleep on the side of the road. They've long since given up on salvation and liminal spaces— yet bridges tie them back to Nothing. These bridges pull, pull, and pull, and one day they will snap so violently that the entire world might collapse from the recoil.

It's important, I think, to break trusses sometimes. Once bits of plaster and steel come crashing down, stories spill out of the water, regardless of how interesting the details are or what *you* really want. Nobody hides unless they've a good reason, and for this reason, there is no need to hear one.

Morie and Antoine never once thought about reasons. Whether you be a gibberish man, an androgynous child, a train, a food safety inspector, *The Scream*, or a cookbook that someone desperately wants to embody, there's no pair better at accepting what comes.

They'll be quite alright in Florida, a land also beyond logic, so long as they trust fate...

And Morie 2, who will be more than happy to take them in.

Thank you for entering the space between time.

Thank you for leaving, walking again, and finally finding your way to the end.

NO, THERE WILL NOT BE A SEQUEL.

SOME THINGS ARE MEANT TO END.